

NEW OBSTACLE PROPOSAL SECURITY CONSOLE

A reversible zone-control obstacle that changes **which problem the player chooses to solve first** - without invalidating the power systems that make late-game Match Villains satisfying.

PART I - OBSTACLE DESIGN



Research basis: 800+ levels played, late-game video review, screenshot catalog, current obstacle benchmark

01 - WHAT THE GAME ALREADY ASKS THE PLAYER TO DO

The obstacle library is already broad. A new item needs a new *decision*, not a new skin.

Across the supplied catalog and gameplay, Match Villains repeatedly varies the **method** of solving a problem: hit count, color requirement, spreading, timing, power-up disruption, staged reveal and movement.

Color / condition

01

Safe, Colored Bulb, Power Core and Grenade Launcher ask for specific colors or states.

Power-up pressure

02

Laser, Camera, Police, Bouncer and Snitch Magnet alter how safely power-ups can be used.

Spread / recovery

03

Sponge Bubble, Syrup, Sand Pot and Tinker Kit create problems that grow or recover.

Reveal / stages

04

ATM, Trojan Horse, Ancient Temple and multi-stage objects turn one task into another.

Timing / movement

05

Chicken, Ice Dragon and Skating Board make state and timing matter from move to move.

Design whitespace

?

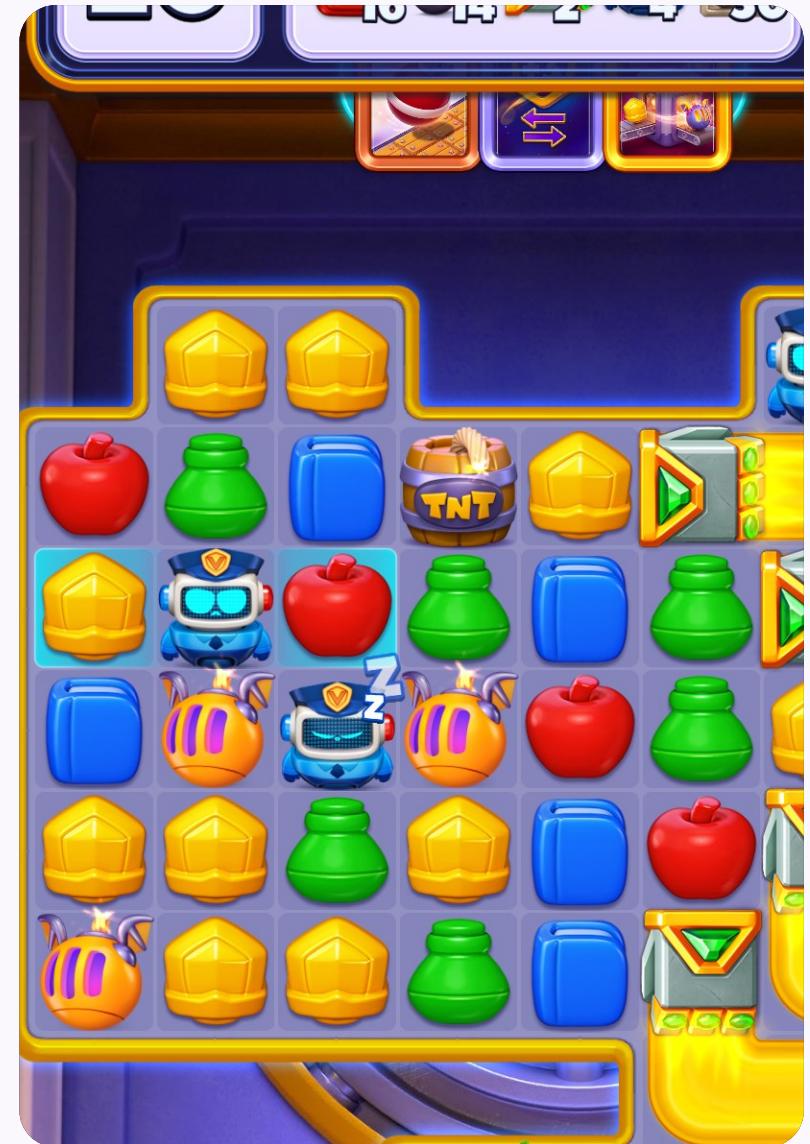
Most obstacles ask: "How do I solve this?" Fewer ask the player to decide **which problem should be active right now.**

"Most obstacles change how the player solves a problem. Security Console changes which problem the player chooses to solve first."

NOT AN ORDERED-COLOR KEYPAD

NOT ANOTHER POWER-UP COUNTER

The ordered-color space is already occupied by Safe-style color requirements and the Grenade Launcher's red > yellow > green > blue sequence in the supplied catalog.

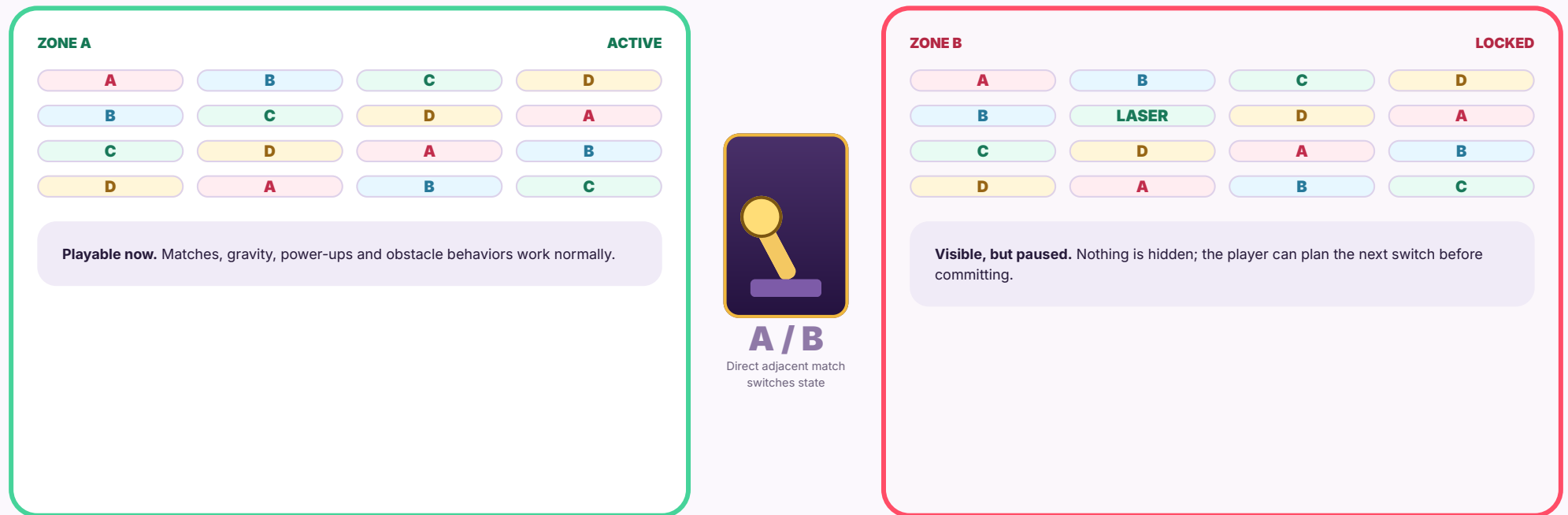


Late-game gameplay evidence: visually dense boards already combine multiple obstacle families. The proposal therefore targets decision structure rather than raw durability.

02 - THE CONCEPT

One console. Two visible zones. Only one is active at a time.

Make a **direct player-created match next to the Console** to switch which connected zone is active. The other zone becomes locked and paused. The Console stays on the board and can be used again.



VISIBLE CHOICE

The locked area is never concealed. The player sees targets, threats and prepared power-ups before switching.

REVERSIBLE

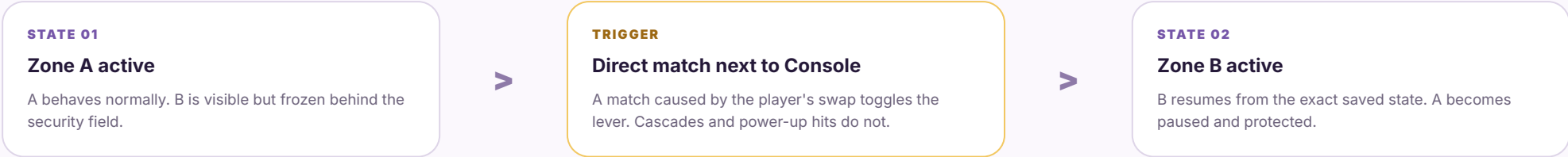
Switching is not a one-way unlock. The player can return later and preserve the exact state of the paused zone.

POWER-PRESERVING

Power-ups remain valuable in the active zone. The mechanic redirects power rather than hard-countering it.

03 - EXACT RULES

The mechanic is intentionally simple; the consequences are systemic.



Rule	Specification	Reason
Footprint	Console occupies 1 tile in a permanently playable shared area.	It should create routing decisions without consuming a large part of the board.
Controlled areas	Exactly 2 zones. Recommended 6-12 cells per zone; shapes can be rectangular, L-shaped or pockets.	Large enough to matter, small enough that the game still feels like one board.
Activation	One direct player-created adjacent match. No activation from cascades, Rockets, TNT, Snitch or autonomous card effects.	Switching must feel intentional, not accidental.
Locked zone	Fully visible. Pieces, gravity, spawns, obstacle timers, spread and repair are paused.	Creates informed planning and avoids hidden-information frustration.
Cross-zone attacks	Rocket beams, Snitch targeting, Thunderball clears and other attacks stop at the security boundary.	"Locked" should have one consistent meaning: protected and inactive.
Persistence	Console is not a level goal and is not destroyed. It remains switchable until objectives are complete.	The value comes from repeated route control, not another durability counter.
Objective placement	At least one mandatory objective must exist in each controlled zone.	Prevents the player from permanently hiding a difficult zone.

Prototype variant to test: if "direct match only" feels too exception-heavy in usability testing, the fallback is a dedicated lever interaction that consumes one move. The core design - reversible zone choice - remains unchanged.

04 - EDGE CASES

"Locked" is a real gameplay state, not a visual cover.

The rule stays consistent across obstacle and power-up systems: a locked zone is **paused, protected and untargetable**. When reopened, every object resumes from where it stopped.

System / obstacle	While its zone is locked	When reopened
Laser / Camera / Police	Threat behavior is paused. No power-up is destroyed, caged or locked from inside the inactive zone.	Resumes from its previous state; no reset exploit.
Sponge Bubble / Syrup / Sand Pot	Spread does not progress. Spread also cannot cross the security boundary.	Continues normally from the saved board state.
Tinker Kit / recovery mechanics	Repair is paused; damage is neither healed nor advanced.	Repair logic resumes.
Snitch / Super Snitch	Locked cells are removed from the valid target pool.	Targets become eligible again.
Rocket / TNT / Poison row clear	Area effects stop at the security boundary with a short deflection effect.	Normal propagation returns.
Thunderball / board-wide effects	Same-color pieces in the locked zone are ignored.	They re-enter the effect pool.
Power Cards	Autonomous attacks such as Bomb Explosion / Dragon Flame / Thor-style effects select only shared + active cells. +Moves is unaffected.	Normal target selection returns.
Linked systems	Pairs such as Power Switch / Twin Tiles should not be authored across opposite Console zones in the base implementation.	Avoids ambiguous remote interactions and keeps the first release readable.

LASER EXAMPLE

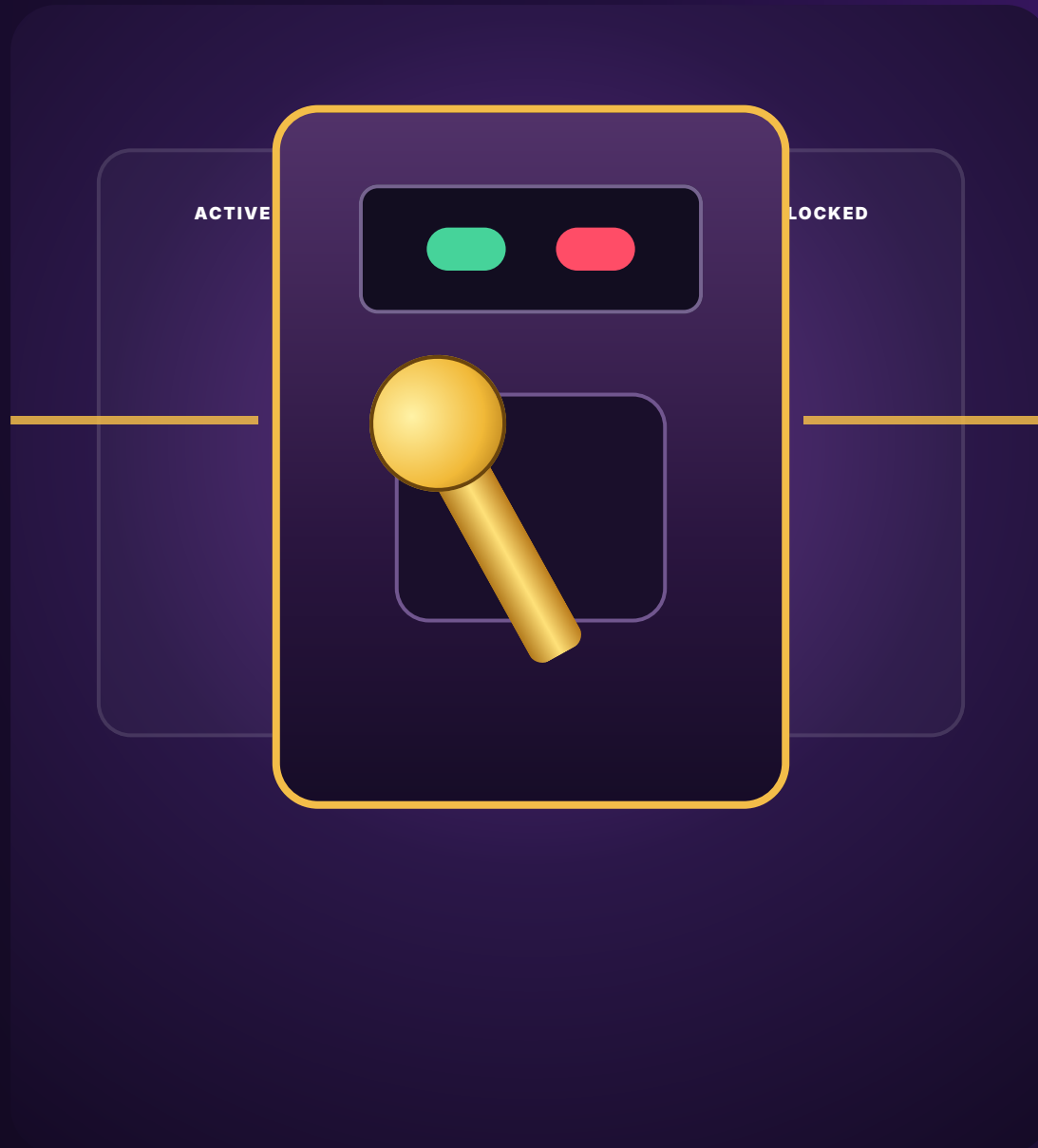
If a Laser sits in Zone B, locking B temporarily neutralizes it. This is intentional strategy, not free removal: objectives in B force the player to reopen it later.

PREPARE + RETURN

A Rocket created in Zone A stays frozen there. The player may work in B, then switch back and use the prepared setup.

NO SOFT LOCKS

The Console always lives in shared space. Shared + active cells must always support legal moves and access to the next switch.



05 - APPEARANCE AND FEEDBACK

Heist-tech, chunky, readable in one glance.

The object should look like something the Villains would use to control a vault floor: a compact brass-and-purple security terminal with a physical lever and two unmistakable status lights.

CONSOLE

1-tile footprint. Gold metal rim, plum body, oversized lever. Left/right indicators show the active connection even before the player looks at the zones.

LOCKED ZONE

Contents remain fully visible under a thin red laser grid, 20-25% dimming and a small lock icon. Never blur or hide obstacle identity.

SWITCH ANIMATION

~0.4 sec: lever snaps with a metallic "CLUNK", old gate scans red, new gate flashes green. Fast enough not to interrupt combo rhythm.

BLOCKED HIT FEEDBACK

A Rocket/Snitch impact on the boundary produces a tiny electrical deflection. The player immediately understands why the hit did not enter.

06 - WHY THIS BELONGS IN THE GAME

It adds agency without taking away the spectacle.

1 rule

Large level-design consequence

The player only learns "switch the active zone." Difficulty comes from what designers place in each zone, not from adding a long exception list to the obstacle itself.

0 hidden info

Choice stays fair

A player can see a Laser, spreader, objective or saved Rocket before changing zones. Wrong decisions cost efficiency, not information the player could never know.

100% reversible

No permanent path trap

The player can recover from a poor route choice by switching again, paying with moves rather than being hard-locked.

Late-game power is not disabled. It is **redirected**.

In the observed late-game state, Super Snitch, Super Thunderball, starting Snitches and Power Cards can make raw durability collapse quickly. Security Console does not solve that by giving an obstacle more HP. It makes the player decide **where that power can currently be applied**.



Design principle: preserve the satisfying cascade/power fantasy, while adding a planning layer that cannot be brute-forced purely by more damage.

Theme fit: Good Job Games describes Match Villains around heists, layered obstacles and hidden/overlaid board structure. A security control device naturally extends that heist vocabulary while enabling a genuinely different board relationship.

07 - LEVEL-DESIGN POTENTIAL

The same rule can create different reasons to switch.

These are not the five requested case levels yet. They are proof that the obstacle has enough design space to support a progression rather than a one-level gimmick.

GOALS LASER**Threat isolation**

Temporarily lock a dangerous Laser zone, make progress elsewhere, then reopen it when prepared.

ROCKET TARGETS**Prepare and return**

Build a power-up in one zone, switch away, then return later to use the preserved setup.

SPREAD SAFE**Priority trade-off**

One zone contains a growing problem while the other contains a large required objective. Both routes are viable.

A B**Asymmetric zones**

A small high-pressure pocket versus a larger easy-production area changes when switching becomes efficient.

Recommended first appearance

One Console, two 3x3 zones, almost no competing obstacle logic. Start with the "wrong" zone active and place an obvious match next to the Console so the first switch teaches the entire mechanic.

Advanced expression

Only after the mechanic is familiar: irregular zones, spreaders, power-up threats, saved setups and potentially a second Console. Complexity should come from combinations, not extra Console rules.

Design target: two players can solve the same level in different orders - and both choices can be reasonable.

08 - TUNING KNOBS

Difficulty should come from choices around the Console, not from making the Console itself harder.

Knob	How it changes difficulty
Zone size	6-12 cells per zone changes how much progress is paused at each switch.
Zone asymmetry	Small-dangerous vs large-productive zones create different route incentives.
Initial active side	Can teach the mechanic or deliberately create an opening dilemma.
Obstacle mix	Laser, spreaders, recovery mechanics and saved power-ups change the value of timing a switch.
Objective split	Balanced goals encourage cycling; uneven goals encourage longer commitments to one side.
Move budget	Every unnecessary switch costs tempo, so move count naturally prices indecision.

Authoring guardrail: one Console for early and mid introductions. Two-Console boards should be reserved for mastery content only after telemetry confirms high comprehension.

09 - PROTOTYPE QUESTIONS

What I would validate before production

H1 - Comprehension

Can players predict which zone will activate after one tutorial exposure? Track tutorial success, first-switch latency and mis-trigger rate.

H2 - Meaningful choice

Do players actually take different first routes? Track first active-zone choice, switch count and route distribution, not only win rate.

H3 - Power-state resilience

Does the obstacle remain interesting at streak 0 and at high-power states? Segment by Super Snitch, Super Thunderball, starting Snitches and Power Cards.

H4 - Fairness

Watch for accidental switches, attacks "wasted" into locked areas, restarts immediately after switching and comments that the field feels arbitrary.

Kill criteria: if players repeatedly trigger the Console unintentionally, if optimal play always means the same route, or if locking makes earned power feel useless, I would simplify or drop the mechanic rather than force it into production.

10 - ONE-LINE PITCH

SECURITY CONSOLE

Choose the problem before solving it.

A persistent 1-tile control device that toggles between two visible board zones. One zone plays normally; the other pauses behind a security field. The player can switch back and forth, deciding when each threat or objective should become active.

NEW DECISION

Priority selection rather than another hit requirement.

GAME FIT

Heist theme + layered board structure + systemic obstacle combos.

SCALABLE

One rule supports tutorials, hard levels and late-game mastery.

Scope note: This document answers only the first case-study prompt: proposing a new Match Villains obstacle, including mechanics and appearance. The five creative levels and 350+ level analysis will follow as separate sections.

RESEARCH BASIS & BENCHMARK REFERENCES

PRIMARY

User-provided Match Villains gameplay through 800+ levels, 131 Drive images, 24 video clips, and the updated obstacle catalog. The catalog distinguishes confirmed observations, inferred mechanics and Royal Match comparisons.

GOOD JOB GAMES

Good Job Games - Games / Match Villains. Used for the game's heist framing and description of multi-layered obstacles.

MATCH VILLAINS

Apple App Store - Match Villains version history. Used to verify the recent obstacle cadence and the descriptions of Electric Shield, Sand Pot, Tinker Kit, Skating Board and Temple Totem.

BENCHMARK

Royal Match - Force Field. A region-protection benchmark: it covers part of a board and is permanently cleared after adjacent matches.

BENCHMARK

Royal Match - Purple Borders. A dynamic-board benchmark: it shifts a portion of the board after every move.

Concept differentiation claim is deliberately narrow: I did not find a directly equivalent player-controlled, reversible A/B zone switch in the reviewed Match Villains catalog or the benchmark mechanics above. This is not a claim that no match-3 game has ever used a similar idea.

FROM MECHANIC TO LEVEL SYSTEM

FIVE LEVELS. FIVE DIFFERENT REASONS TO SWITCH.

The goal is not to repeat the Security Console five times. Each concept level isolates a different decision: learning the state change, prioritizing a spreader, creating a safe attack window, managing a destructive shortcut, and mastering a staged heist.

01 TEACH

Learn what
active vs locked
means.

02 PRIORITIZE

Choose which
mandatory
problem to
contain first.

03 PREPARE

Build power in
shared space
before opening
danger.

**04 TRADE
OFF**

Use a helpful
obstacle without
deleting value.

05 MASTER

Cycle zones
through a multi-
stage Big Heist
structure.

The progression increases **decision complexity**, not rule complexity.

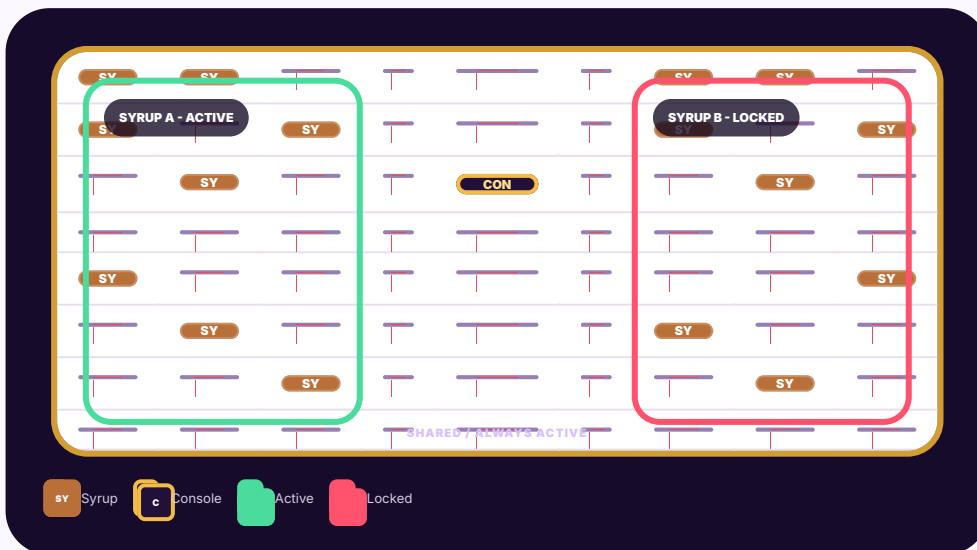
All move counts and objective quantities are prototype starting points for playtesting, not claims about production tuning.



LEVEL 01 - FIRST SWITCH

Teach the entire mechanic with one obvious A → B transition.

Two small target pockets, no competing advanced obstacle logic. Zone A starts active; Zone B is visible and locked.



18

MOVES

12

SYRUP

1+

SWITCHES

PLAYER LESSON

Locked does not mean hidden. Clear the active pocket, then use the obvious adjacent match to switch and finish the second pocket.

WHY IT FITS

The board starts constrained and then opens the player's attention to a second visible problem, matching the game's frequent phase-based level rhythm without adding another tutorial rule.

FAILURE MODE

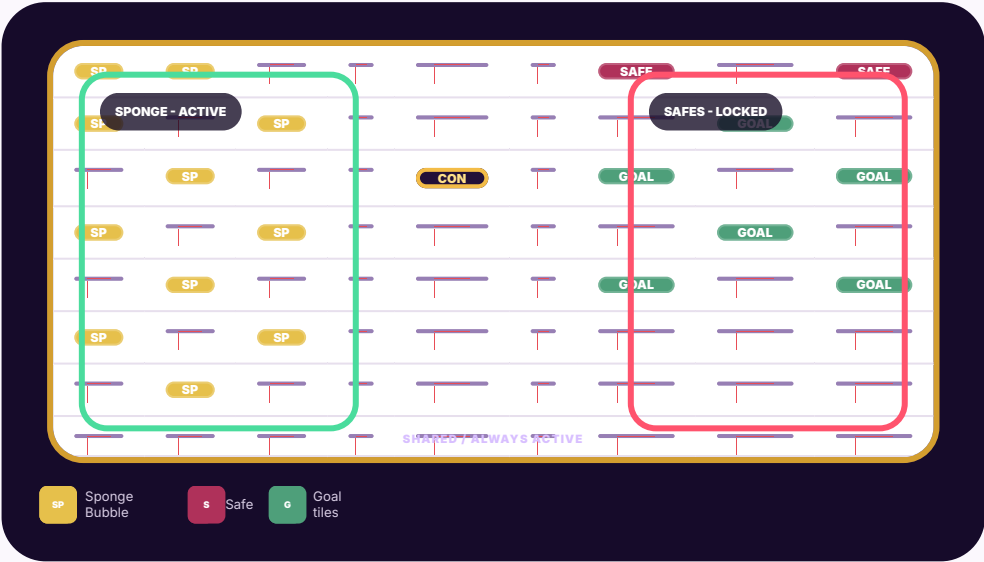
If players keep matching around the Console after the switch or expect the locked zone to disappear, visual feedback is insufficient. This level exists primarily to validate comprehension.

One switch should be enough to understand the obstacle.

LEVEL 02 - CONTAINMENT CHOICE

Both zones are mandatory. Only one problem can progress at a time.

Zone A contains Sponge Bubble pressure; Zone B contains two Safes. Locking A pauses spread, but every move spent on B delays the cleanup waiting in A.



24
MOVES

2
SAFES

16
BUBBLE TILES*

CORE DECISION

Contain the spreader now, or pause it and work on the color-gated Safes? The level should support both openings, creating route variety instead of a single scripted solution.

CREATIVE TOUCH

The Console becomes a temporary containment tool. That is useful, but not a free win: objectives in both wings force the player to reopen the problem eventually.

TUNING LEVER

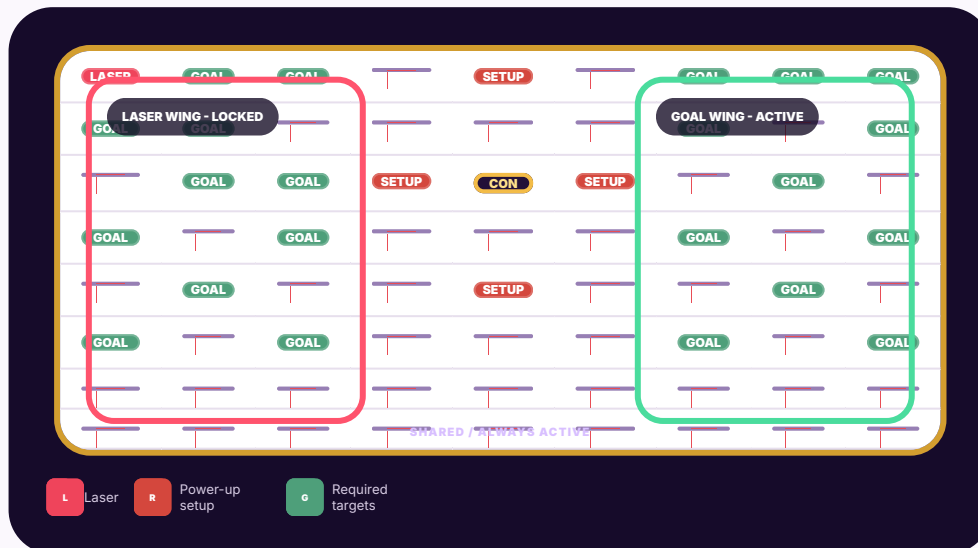
Change only the starting density of Sponge Bubble and the Safe color requirements. If one opening dominates, adjust pressure rather than adding new Console rules.

*Prototype objective count represents the amount of bubble-covered space to clear after spread. Final count depends on the production implementation of Sponge Bubble.

LEVEL 03 - LASER WINDOW

Prepare in safety. Open the dangerous wing only when the attack window is ready.

A three-column shared hub remains playable at all times. Zone A holds a Laser and required goals. Zone B holds simpler goals. Rocket-friendly setups in the hub reward preparation.



22

MOVES

1

LASER

15

GOALS

CORE DECISION

Use the shared hub to create power-ups while the Laser wing is locked, then switch A active and spend those prepared attacks before the threat becomes expensive.

IMPORTANT INTERACTION

Attacks cannot cross into a locked zone. The player must intentionally open the wing first. This prevents the Console from becoming a trivial way to damage danger from total safety.

WHY IT FITS LATE GAME

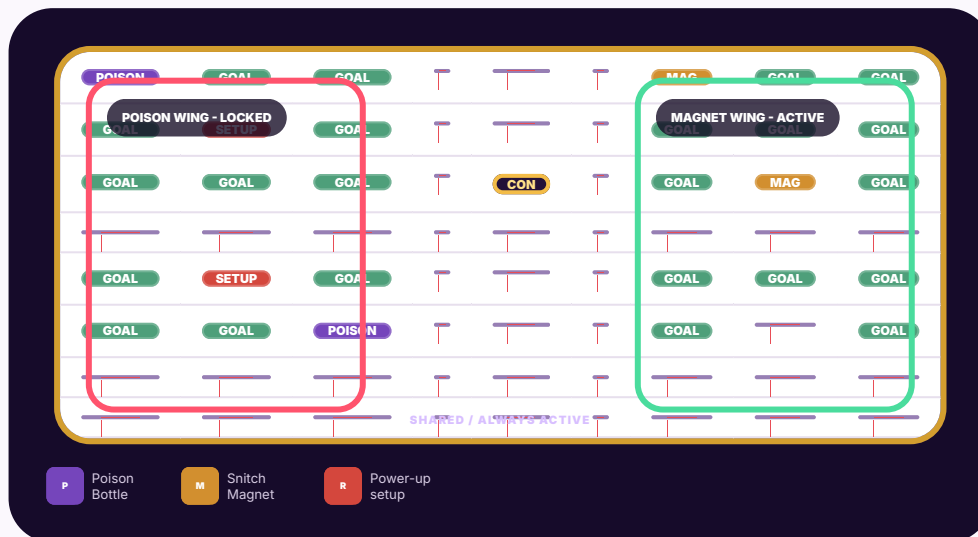
High-power states still matter: Super Snitch, Rockets and Power Cards remain strong. The challenge is deciding **when their targets should become eligible**, not artificially disabling earned power.

Prepare → switch → burst → retreat.

LEVEL 04 - RISKY SHORTCUT

A helpful clear can also destroy value. Sequence matters more than raw damage.

Zone A contains Poison Bottles aligned with goal rows and two valuable power-up setups. Zone B contains Snitch Magnets and mandatory goals.



25

MOVES

2

POISON

2

MAGNETS

CORE DECISION

Poison can wipe an entire line and save moves, but it can also remove a power-up caught in that line. The player chooses whether to cash the shortcut now or preserve the setup first.

CONSOLE CONTRIBUTION

The player can lock the Poison wing while solving the Magnet wing, preserving an unfinished setup. Returning later turns the switch into a deliberate sequencing tool rather than a simple defensive button.

FAILURE MODE

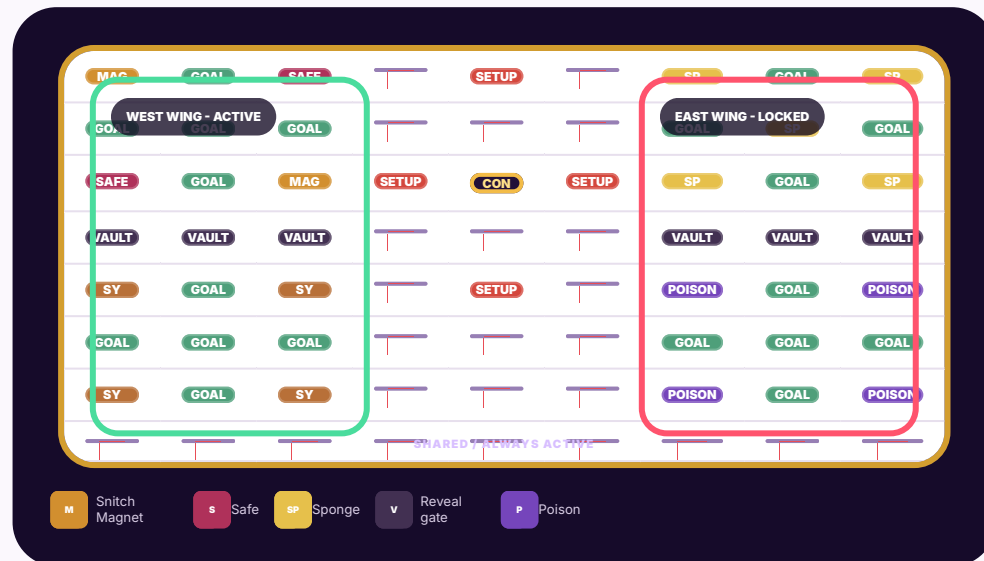
Trigger Poison too early and a prepared power-up disappears. Delay it too long and the row-clear value is wasted. Both failures are understandable and recoverable, not random.

This level deliberately combines two mechanics that affect power value in different ways: Poison can destroy it, while Snitch Magnet changes how comfortably Snitch power can be exploited.

LEVEL 05 - GRAND SECURITY HEIST

A staged board that forces the player to revisit both wings instead of solving each once.

The top half is the opening security layer. Clearing both wings unlocks lower vault pockets, creating a second decision cycle with different obstacle pressure.



32

MOVES

3

PHASES

3-5

EXPECTED SWITCHES

PHASE 1 - BREACH

West: Magnet + Safe. East: Sponge pressure. Both sides contain mandatory progress.

PHASE 2 - REVEAL

Completing the upper security layer opens the lower vault pockets while preserving the current Console state.

PHASE 3 - CASH OUT

Lower west adds Syrup; lower east adds Poison. The player must choose the final route based on board state, not a fixed script.

WHY THIS IS THE MASTERY LEVEL

The Console rule never changes. Difficulty comes from remembering saved states, forecasting the next reveal, and deciding when each wing deserves attention.

BIG HEIST FIT

The multi-stage reveal mirrors the recorded late-game Big Heist rhythm: a visually dense board becomes a sequence of smaller problems that unlock one another.

The final level tests planning across phases, not memorization of extra rules.

DESIGN RATIONALE

One mechanic. A growing decision space.

The five levels introduce no new Security Console rules after Level 1. Complexity is created through obstacle combinations, zone asymmetry, saved board states and staged reveals.

Level	What changes	Decision being tested	Primary tuning knob
01 First Switch			
02 Containment Choice			
03 Laser Window			
04 Risky Shortcut			
05 Grand Security Heist			

WHAT I WOULD MEASURE

ROUTE DISTRIBUTION

First active-zone choice and first three switch decisions. If every successful player takes the same route, the choice is probably fake.

SWITCH EFFICIENCY

Switches per win, unnecessary back-and-forth, and moves spent immediately after switching. This shows whether the mechanic creates planning or only friction.

STATE-ADJUSTED DIFFICULTY

First-attempt win rate, moves left and continue usage segmented by Super Snitch, Super Thunderball, starting Snitches and Power Cards.

FAILURE CAUSE

Did the player run out of moves with goals concentrated in one wing? Lose a prepared power-up to Poison? Reopen danger too early? Failure should be interpretable.

Success criterion: players should understand the rule quickly, then disagree about the best route.

Source basis: user-provided Match Villains gameplay/screenshots and updated obstacle catalog. Level layouts are original concept designs. Move and objective counts are prototype hypotheses to be tuned through playtesting.

BEYOND THE 350-LEVEL REQUIREMENT

DIFFICULTY IS NOT JUST A CURVE. IT IS A PLAYER STATE.

After progressing beyond 800 levels, my strongest observation was not simply that boards became more complex. The relationship between board design, streak bonuses, Power Cards and continuation decisions changed how difficulty was actually experienced.

800+

LEVELS REACHED

350+

REQUIRED BY CASE

9POWER CARDS
OBSERVED**818-833**RECORDED LATE-
GAME RANGE

A hard-looking board can feel easy when the player enters it with a strong enough power state.

This section separates direct gameplay observations from product hypotheses and recommended telemetry.



HOW I APPROACHED THE ANALYSIS

I treated the playthrough as a product study, not a speedrun.

The case asks for obstacle categorization, difficulty progression and core mechanics after at least 350 levels. I went beyond that threshold and used screenshots plus recorded late-game sessions to preserve specific states instead of relying only on memory.

800+

Progression depth used to observe how the obstacle language evolves.

131

Gameplay / meta screenshots reviewed in the working set, including duplicates and system states.

24

Short gameplay recordings in the updated video folder, including six split segments from an earlier long recording.

818-833

Dense late-game range used as a focused sample for board flow and player-state observations.

I do not treat a personal playthrough as population data.

Observed behavior tells me what to investigate. Internal telemetry would be required to quantify how common each pattern is across the player base.

Three evidence labels used in this section

OBSERVED - directly visible in my playthrough, screenshots or recordings.

WOULD MEASURE - telemetry I would request from the product data stack.

HYPOTHESIS - a product interpretation that should be validated, not presented as fact.

WHAT THE PLAYTHROUGH WAS USED TO ANSWER

1. Obstacle language

What kind of decisions do early, mid and late obstacles create?

2. Difficulty progression

What makes a level feel hard after the player's power systems ramp up?

3. Core level rhythm

How do restricted openings, reveals and power-up release phases shape play?

4. Product systems

How do streaks, Power Cards and continue offers change the meaning of a win or loss?

Source basis: candidate gameplay recordings/screenshots and the updated obstacle catalog. Public benchmark comparisons in Parts I-II are used as context; this section focuses on first-hand gameplay evidence.

A QUALITATIVE PROGRESSION MAP

Obstacles evolve from readability tests into systems that manipulate timing, power-ups and board state.

The level bands below summarize the dominant design job I observed. They are not a claim that every level in a band follows the same pattern.

01-70

Teach the grammar

- Layered blockers: Box, Pumpkin, Emerald.
- Color / condition checks: Safe, Colored Bulb.
- Board-space goals: Syrup, Violets, Soil.
- Simple movement: Armadillo.
- First power-up threat: Laser and Camera.

Design job: teach what can be hit, what must be collected, and what should be prioritized - with high visual readability.

70-350

Interrupt the default plan

- Recovery / timing: Ice Wall.
- Reactive devices: Coil and Grenade Launcher.
- Power-up control: Robot Police, Hungry Flower.
- Multi-stage chains: Fish Tank, Sword Rack.
- Delayed payoff: Mjolnir / board-wide helper effects.

Design job: make the player change sequencing. A good power-up is no longer automatically safe to save.

350-800

Create system interactions

- Power-up redirection: Bouncer, Snitch Magnet.
- Useful-but-dangerous effects: Poison Bottles.
- Spreading / secondary burden: Sponge Duck, Syrup Bottle, Money Bag.
- Linked / global logic: Power Switch, Fist Bump.
- State changes: Chickens, Disco Ball, hidden board layers.

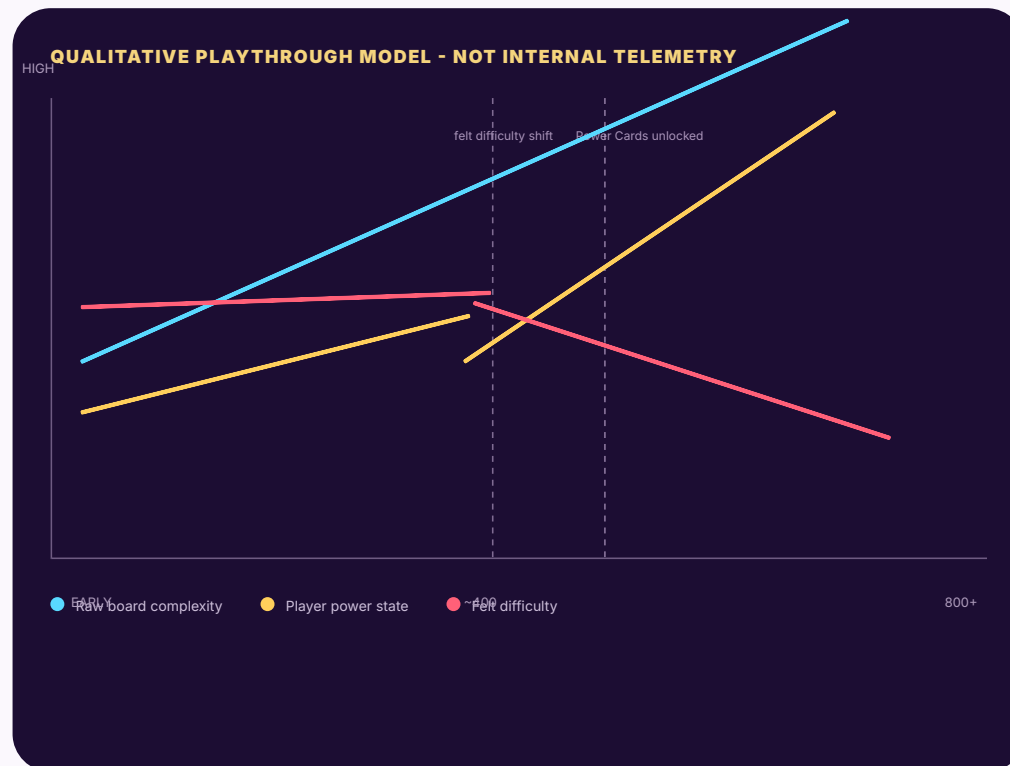
Design job: challenge the relationship between systems. The question becomes less "Can I break this?" and more "When and in what order should I interact with it?"

The strongest later obstacles do not simply add hit points. They change the player's priority map.

THE KEY FINDING

Visual complexity kept rising. My felt difficulty did not.

From roughly the 400s onward, the playthrough felt materially easier even though boards looked denser and more segmented. Power Cards unlocked around the 450-500 range, while streak bonuses had already increased the player's starting power.



Effective difficulty $\approx$ Raw board challenge - Current player power state



5 wins

Start the level with 4 Snitches.

7 wins

Super Snitch state; normal Snitch no longer appears.

10 wins

Super Thunderball activates and doubles Thunderball effect.

OBSERVED IMPLICATION

A late board can contain more blockers, pockets and reveal steps than an early board, yet still collapse quickly once the opening structure is breached.

WHAT I WOULD VALIDATE

Level win rate segmented by streak state. If Level X is 45% first-attempt at streak 0 and 80% at streak 10, its single aggregate win rate hides the actual player experience.

A level that is hard at streak 0 can be a different puzzle at streak 10.

LOADOUT BEHAVIOR

Once I found a reliable trio, the system gave me little reason to change it.

Nine Power Cards were visible in the current build. My recurring loadout used Bomb Explosion, +3 Moves and Snitch Factory - three broadly useful effects that do not require knowing the exact board in advance.



Power Cards add meaningful power, but not enough reasons to change your loadout once a combination consistently works.

IMPORTANT UX DETAIL

The three cards can be changed before entering the level, but not as a board-specific counter-pick after inspecting the layout. This makes the system closer to a general loadout than a tactical response layer.

PRODUCT OPPORTUNITY - HYPOTHESIS**Encourage experimentation without removing agency.**

Instead of fully randomizing cards, I would test softer variation mechanisms: rotating featured cards, a 3-of-5 draft, temporary rewards for unused cards, or episode modifiers.

METRICS

Loadout concentration, card swap rate, unique cards used per 20 levels, win rate by loadout, and whether experimentation changes retention or only adds friction.

HOW LATE LEVELS BREATHE

The board often starts as a puzzle and ends as a spectacle.

Across late-game screenshots and recordings, many boards restrict the opening space, then release more playable area and finally reveal additional targets. This creates a strong shift in tempo.



1

OPENING - find the first unlock

Limited playable area and obstacle pressure make early moves more deliberate. The goal is often to free space, expose a device, or break the first gate.

2

RELEASE - power creation accelerates

Once the central structure opens, more adjacent matches become available. Snitches, Rockets, TNT and cascades are created more easily.

3

REVEAL - the level may change shape

Hidden targets, lower pockets or a new obstacle stage appear. The player realizes the original board was only the first layer.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR DIFFICULTY

A board can look intimidating because it contains many blocked cells, but if the first unlock creates a large release phase, the remaining work may become much easier than the opening image suggests.

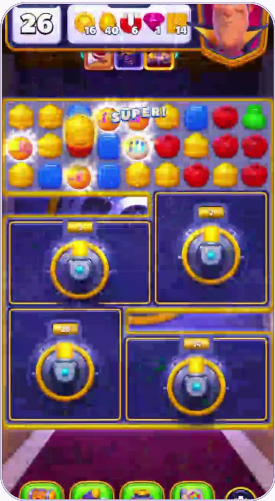
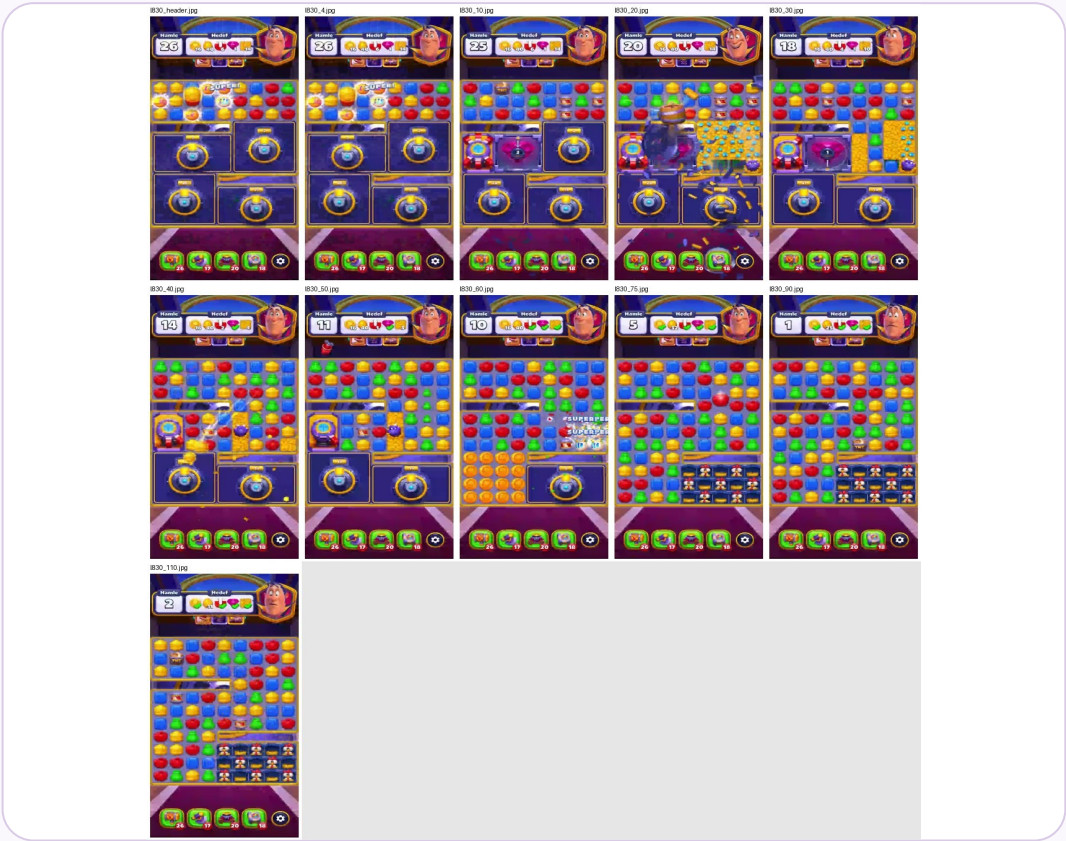
Visual complexity != effective difficulty.

The meaningful question is how many constrained decisions stand between the player and the point where the board starts solving itself.

A WIN THAT THE ORIGINAL MOVE BUDGET DID NOT SOLVE

Level 830 required two continuation purchases in the captured run.

The level began with 26 moves and a multi-stage structure. The board transformed as the upper layer was cleared and lower objectives became available.



26
INITIAL MOVES



+5 / 900
FIRST CONTINUE



+5 / 1900
SECOND CONTINUE + AID

Win rate alone would label this a success. Move-budget performance tells a different story.

OBSERVED
The recorded attempt spent 2,800 coins across two continue offers before completing the level.

PRODUCT IMPLICATION
I would distinguish **level completion** from **solved within original move budget**. The latter better preserves the underlying difficulty signal when continues are available.

STATE-ADJUSTED LEVEL HEALTH

A single win-rate number is not enough for this game.

I would evaluate every level through both board performance and the power state the player carried into it.

Metric	Why it matters	Critical segmentation	Evidence label
First-attempt win rate	Cleanest high-level difficulty signal before retry learning.	Streak 0 / 5 / 7 / 10, Power Cards active, booster start	WOULD MEASURE
Attempts per success	Separates a one-off close loss from repeated blocking.	Level, obstacle mix, player cohort	WOULD MEASURE
Moves left on win	Detects levels that are technically passed but over-tuned in the easy direction.	Player power state and loadout	WOULD MEASURE
Goals left on fail	Shows whether failures are near-misses or structurally far from completion.	Goal type / obstacle stage	WOULD MEASURE
Continue purchase rate	Separates true board completion from economy-assisted completion.	Streak state, remaining goals, offer number	WOULD MEASURE
Power Card loadout	Reveals dominant combinations and whether card variety exists in practice.	Card trio, swaps, level band	WOULD MEASURE
Power-up creation / use	Quantifies when a board enters the release phase and starts cascading.	Opening 10 moves vs rest of level	WOULD MEASURE
Retry / quit after fail	Difficulty only becomes harmful when it changes behavior.	Fail margin, streak lost, continue declined	WOULD MEASURE

BOARD VIEW

What was the level asking?

Playable area, target count, reveal depth, obstacle families, refill constraints and power-up opportunities.

PLAYER-STATE VIEW

What did the player bring?

Starting Snitches, Super Snitch, Super Thunderball, Power Cards, boosters, coin balance and previous streak.

BEHAVIOR VIEW

What happened after pressure?

Continue, retry, quit, card swap, booster use, session end, or immediate next-level play.

OBSERVATIONS BECOME QUESTIONS

The playthrough produced four hypotheses worth testing with real player data.

HYPOTHESIS 01

The streak system creates a positive power flywheel.

Winning unlocks stronger starting power, which can make the next board easier and increase the probability of preserving the streak.

Test: compare next-level win rate and moves-left across identical levels by incoming streak state.

HYPOTHESIS 02

A continue protects more than five moves.

If failure resets accumulated streak power, a player near the end of a level is also protecting future starting power - not only the current board.

Test: continue conversion by streak state, fail margin, offer number and expected streak value.

HYPOTHESIS 03

Power Card loadouts may become sticky.

Because cards are selected before the board and broad utility combinations work across many levels, players may settle into one trio rather than explore the full system.

Test: card swap rate, loadout concentration and a rotating-featured-card experiment.

HYPOTHESIS 04

Reveal depth predicts difficulty better than visual density.

Levels with several dependent stages can consume more of the move budget than boards that initially look more crowded but open into a large cascade space.

Test: model fail rate against number of required stages, playable-area growth and first-release move.

The goal is not to prove these hypotheses from one account. It is to turn gameplay observations into measurable product questions.

800+ LEVELS LATER

WHAT I WOULD TAKE INTO THE INTERVIEW.

The most useful output of the playthrough is not a list of hard levels. It is a model of how board design and player-state systems combine to create the actual experience.

Difficulty should be evaluated as a relationship between the board and the player state entering it.

This analysis is based on personal gameplay, candidate-provided captures and the updated obstacle catalog. Any population-level conclusion would require Good Job Games internal telemetry.

01 - OBSTACLES

Later obstacles increasingly change priority, timing and power-up behavior instead of only adding durability.

02 - DIFFICULTY

Raw board complexity and felt difficulty can diverge when streak bonuses and Power Cards accumulate.

03 - LEVEL FLOW

Restricted opening → release → reveal is a recurring rhythm that lets levels feel puzzle-like first and explosive later.

04 - ECONOMY

A completion after paid continuation should not be treated as equivalent to solving within the original move budget.

05 - PRODUCT DESIGN

The strongest opportunity is to create new decisions, not simply stronger blockers. This principle directly informed the Security Console proposal in Parts I-II.